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THOSE FIRST MONTHS after the Iran-Contra affair hit the front pages were frustrating for me. For the first time in my life, people didn't believe me. I had told the truth, but they still didn't believe me. While I was unhappy, I never felt depressed about the situation: There wasn't a gloom or "malaise" hanging over the Oval Office, as some writers have suggested. I just went on with my job.

Nancy says I never get depressed, and it's true that I tend to see the positive things in life. In this case, I didn't feel that I had done anything to feel depressed about. There's a difference between having done something wrong and feeling bad about it, on the one hand, and, on the other, having an inner feeling that says you haven't done anything wrong—and that's how I felt. I knew everything I had done was within the law and within the president's powers. But if I wasn't depressed about what was going on, I sure felt frustrated that I couldn't get my message across.

Every autumn, just before Thanksgiving, the president is presented with a huge turkey in celebration of Turkey Day; in 1986, it weighed fifty-eight pounds. What many people don't know is that the president and his family don't sit down and eat this behemoth bird: It's a ceremonial gobbler brought for picture-taking. Then it returns home, possibly to make a return appearance the following year. It's never put in an oven. But that Thanksgiving, which we spent at Rancho del Cielo, I felt I was the one being roasted.

The pundits claimed that the administration was "paralyzed" and "dead in the water." That wasn't true. We were still proceeding with our domestic and foreign policy programs. We had all kinds of things we were battling for